

Ballmer talk

Microsoft's Chief Executive Steve Ballmer has expressed regret over the late start in the search engine business. This statement comes after Bing managed a mere 8 per cent market share.

Long sceptical of Tim Berners-Lee's vision of the semantic web, Digit's Edward Henning met up recently in London with Gianpiero Lotito, co-founder of the Italian company Facility, and discovered that there are other ways to organise and retrieve the information out there on the web. And they're coming to a PC near you soon.

Facility:

The next evolutionary step in search?

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One of the interesting, and perhaps key, points about the history of the Facility search engine is that the project grew out of a publishing background. One of the two founders of Facility, Gianpiero Lotito has worked in the publishing sector for many years, transferring the processes there over to digital systems.

He told me "We began to work with desktop publishing in 1987, with Aldus Pagemaker on the Mac, together with Adobe Illustrator. We were one of the first companies in Italy to work with DTP, in Milan, and soon, after about a year or year and a half, we started to work with big publishers. In this way we began to work with many big projects, which were being transferred from analogue processes to digital processes. To help them make this passage, we began to learn the core of the processes, we began to learn and understand the secrets of the publishing workflow and processes. In about three years we had learned to work with all the modern digital technologies: multi-media, CD-ROM, internet sites and so on.

"Through ten to fifteen years, we came to learn these processes for books, magazines, archives, photo-guides, CD-ROMs and so on, and we translated all these processes into an idea: the next generation search that is not only able to search and to find information, but is also able to organise it and to manage it. The problem for the next generation of search engine is to help people to organise information. I agree with your earlier comment that the semantic web is a chimera. Also, if it were possible to tag everything on the web (as suggested, for example, by Tim Berners-Lee), if this is not coordinated, if you have no standard, then you lose the advantage of tagging. On the other hand, if you have purely algorithmic engines, you cannot solve many search problems."

The work on developing a next-generation search engine started in 2001 – so what is wrong with existing search engines? Lotito explained to me the difference, as he sees it, between the approach of the engineer, typified, presumably by Google, and the approach of the publisher. The engineer's approach would consider the perfect map of London to be on a scale of 1:1 – it would be the same size as London, and would contain every single detail. But this is not practical – you cannot put it in your pocket. The job of the publisher is to find that balance; to make the map small enough to fit in your